

Chapter-12

Modal Auxiliaries (Special Verbs for Special Expressions)

Read the sets of conversation given below carefully.

Set-1

Francis: I have put on a lot of weight. What do you **advise** me to lose weight?

Doctor: I have a list of things you **should** do to lose weight.

1. You **should** go for a brisk walk every day.
2. You **should** exercise regularly.
3. You **should** reduce the intake of butter, ghee, refined flour and sweets.
4. You **should** drink a lot of water.
5. You **should** measure your weight regularly to keep it controlled.

Set-2

Teacher: Good morning students. I am your new class teacher.

Students: Very good morning madam. Welcome to our class.

Teacher: Thank you dear. I have prepared a list of **rules** that you must follow in the class and the school. Always remember these rules.

1. You **must** keep your class neat and clean.
2. You **must** come to school regularly.
3. You **must** remain disciplined in the class and the school.
4. You **must** complete your work on time.
5. You **must** prepare well for your exams.

You can observe that the word 'should' is used to express the expression of 'advice' in the first conversation. Similarly, in the second conversation, the word, 'must' is used to express the expression of 'obligation' as the students have to follow the rules mentioned here. These words, 'should' and 'must' are called Modal Auxiliaries.

A modal auxiliary is a helping verb used with the first form of some other verb to talk about special expressions such as possibility, permission, request, intention, advice, suggestion, promise, obligation, duty etc.

Use of Can/Could

1. **To express ability:** 'Can' is used to express ability in the present and 'could' is used to express ability in the past.

Examples: Rohan **can** drive a car.

Rohan **could** drive a car when he was 14 years old.

2. **To express possibility:** Can is used to express a general possibility. 'Could' is used to express a weak possibility.

Examples: You **can** get this book in the library. (a common book which is easily available)

You **could** get this book in the library. (a rare book)

3. **To express request:** 'Can' is used to express a request in an informal way. 'Could' is used to make a very polite request or a request in a very formal situation. In this case, 'could' is more formal than modal auxiliaries 'can' and 'may'.

Examples: **Can** you please help me solve this sum?

Could you tell me the way to The Principal's office?

4. **To express permission:** 'Can' is used to take permission in an informal situation. 'Could' is used to express permission in the past or asking for permission in a formal and polite way.

Examples: **Jessica:** Mother, **can** I go out to play with my friends?

Mother: Yes you **can** but only after completing your work.

Employee to Boss: Sir, **could** I get a day's off today, I am not feeling well?

My father told me that I **could** go to watch a movie.

Fill in the blanks with 'can' or 'could':

1. Sheread and write English well.
2. I told him that he.....accompany me.
3. He.....drive a car at the age of twelve.
4. Hebe aggressive sometimes.
5.you lend me some money? (very polite)
6. He help you if you want.
7. He.....come to meet me any time.
8. Ihave availed myself of the opportunity. (But I didn't)
9. Whobe kinder than God?
10. Three years ago, henot even walk.

Use of May/Might

1.To grant or seek permission formally: 'May' is more formal and polite than 'can'. 'Might' is also used to seek permission very politely, mostly with hesitation, but it is less used than 'may'.

Examples: The Principal to the student: You **may** leave now.

Peon to the boss: **May** I come in, sir?

Candidate to the interviewer: **Might**, I come in sir?

2. To express a wish: 'May' is used to express a wish in present. 'Might' is used to express a wish in the past.

Examples: **May** God bless you!

May you win the match!

He wished that God **might** bless me.

3. To express a possibility: 'May' is used to express a good possibility whereas 'might' is used to express a weak or remote possibility. 'Might' is also used to express possibility in the past.

Examples: It is cloudy today. It **may** rain.

It **might** rain today.

He thought that he **might** win the lottery.

4. To express a purpose: 'May' is used to express a purpose in present or future. 'Might' is used to express a purpose in the past.

Examples: He is working hard so that he **may** pass the examination.

He worked hard so that he **might** pass the examination.

Exercise: Fill in the blanks with 'may' or 'might'.

1.I go home now?
2. She asked if she.....read my book.
3. We eat so that we.....live.
4.God bless you!
5. Itrain today. (weak possibility)
6. You.....have won the race if you had taken an early start.

7. If you apologise, he..... forgive you.
8. She.....have applied for a job, but I am not sure.
9.his soul rest in peace!
10. He is working hard so that he.....stand first in the class.

Use of should/ought to/must

‘Should’, ‘ought to’ and ‘must’ are used to give advice or express necessity, duty or obligation. However, the three differ in terms of intensity.

- ⇒ Should is not very forceful. It is used to show a moral duty or obligation or something that is good to do.
- ⇒ Ought is more forceful than should, it is mostly used in formal situations. It is used to express a situational necessity which demands that something has to be done. Still the listener is free to choose whether to do the thing suggested or not.
- ⇒ Must is the most forceful. It suggests that the listener has no choice left. It is used to express a strong obligation, compulsion, order or rule.

Examples: You should give up drinking. (a simple advice)
You should take care of your health. (good for your health)
You should serve your country. (good for country and citizens)
We should help the poor. (moral obligation)
You ought to take medicine regularly. (Otherwise you will not get well soon.)
You ought to prepare well for your exams.
He ought to submit the report by tomorrow as the dead line is near.
The patient is critical. He must be taken to the hospital. (compulsion)
We all must follow the traffic rules. (rule)

Exercise: Fill in the blanks with ‘should’, ‘ought to’ or ‘must’.

1. A judge.....be honest and unbiased.
2. The richhelp the poor.
3. Citizens.....pay their taxes on time.
4. Youtake the test tomorrow.
5. We.....talk politely to others.
6. Youmeet the deadlines of the project.
7. One.....not talk loudly in the library.
8. It is very late. You.....go home now.
9. You.....complete your work by tomorrow, or you would be fined.
10. Younot keep a gun without a licence.

Use of will/would

1. To express future: 'Will' is used to express future tense or make a prediction. 'Would' is used to express the past tense of future.

Examples: He says that he **will** go to Delhi tomorrow.

He said that he **would** go to Delhi the next day.

2. To express willingness/intention or determination: 'Will' expresses more determination than 'would'.

Examples: He says that he **will** help me. (more determined to help)

He says that he **would** help me. (less determined to help)

3. To express a habit: 'Will' is used to express a present habit whereas 'would' is used to express a past habit or routine.

Examples: He **will** always come late.

He **would** always come late when he was a student.

When I was a student, I **would** play cricket.

4. Would is also used to express liking or preference. It is also used to express a desire.

Examples: What **would** you like to have tea or coffee?

I **would** rather die than beg.

Would that I were rich! (desire)

Use of Shall

1. To express simple future or prediction when the subject is the pronoun of the first person:

Examples: I shall meet you tomorrow.

We shall go for a picnic next week.

2. To express suggestion (in yes/no question with 'we' as subject):

Examples: Shall we start the game?

Shall we play cards?

3. To express volition/will of the listener (In yes/no questions with 'I' as subject):

Examples: Shall I come tomorrow? (Do you want me to come?)

Shall I make some tea for you? (Do you want so?)

4. In declarative sentences: to express willingness, intention or insistence of the speaker: In this case 'shall' is used with II and III persons.

Examples: He shall go. (It is my order.)

He will go. (He insists on his going)

He shall be rewarded for his act of bravery. (promise)

You shall attend the class. (I order so.)

Jack will do it. (simple future)

Jack shall do it. (I will see to it that jack does it.)

You will not betray my trust. (your determination)

You shall not betray my trust. (order/ threat)

5. To express a command, compulsion, legal obligation or prohibition when the Subject is the Second or Third Person:

Examples: He shall do the job. (command)

The students shall attend the class. (compulsion)

The people shall submit their income tax return before the end of March. (legal obligation)

You shall not smoke here. (prohibition)

Fill in the blanks with 'will', 'shall' or 'would'.

1. Isurely help you (determination)
2. Youlove your neighbour as yourself. (command)
3. Shealways come late. (present habit)
4. They.....sit for hours talking together. (past habit)
5.that I were the Prime Minister!(wish/desire)
6. Heplay the match. (willingness but not much determined)
7. Younot leave this place. (order)
8.I bring some tea for you? (Do you want me to do so?)
9. Isend him to jail. (threat)
10.I bring you a chair to sit?(offer)

Use of Used to

1. To express a habit in the past or a discontinued habit: It does not have a present tense form.

Examples: He used to go out for a walk every morning.

As a child, she used to love dolls.

I am not used to such treatment.

2. 'Used to be' is used to express something that existed in the past.

Examples: There used to be a park where there is a shopping complex now.

There used to be a hotel in the heart of the city.

Use of need

As a modal auxiliary, 'need' is used to express necessity/obligation in negative or interrogative sentences.

Examples: He need not go there again.

She need not worry for her test.

Need I stay here?

No, you need not stay here.

Use of dare

'Dare' is used to express 'courage' or 'venture'.

Examples: He dare not oppose me.

How dare you insult me?

He dare not face me.

Exercise: Fill in the blanks with 'used to', 'dare' or 'need'.

1. They..... not rewrite their lessons.
2. She.....come late to school every day.
3. You..... not waste time on it.
4. Younot see him; just write a letter.
5. The students not make a noise.

6. Ibe very naught in my childhood.
7. The boys.....not enter the Principal's office.
8. My grand mothergo for a morning walk in her youth.
9. I..... not go out in the dark.
10. You.....not go to market. I have brought the grocery.

A Quick Review of Modal Auxiliaries

Modal	Example	Expression
Can	I can solve this sum. My friend can come today. Can I take your umbrella? Can you lend me some money?	shows ability shows possibility shows seeking permission making request informally
Could	You could easily catch the train. He could be in the library. Could I take a leave tomorrow? Could I speak to the manager?	shows ability in past shows a weak possibility shows seeking permission hesitatingly shows a very polite, formal request
May	May I say something, sir? May you get well soon! He has worked very hard. He may stand first in the class. He leaves home early so that he may catch the train.	shows seeking permission formally shows a wish shows a good possibility shows purpose
Might	He asked if he might say something. He is sincere; he might do well in life. He worked hard so that he might stand first in the class.	seeking permission in past shows a remote possibility shows purpose in the past
should	You should obey your elders. You should return my book tomorrow. He should lose weight. We should keep the city clean.	shows advice shows obligation shows necessity shows moral obligation
Ought	You ought not to be late. You ought to go home now. It is very dark.	shows an obligation (formal situation) shows necessity
Must	You must be punctual. He must abide by the rules of the company. We must have a licence to drive a vehicle.	shows duty/necessity/compulsion/ order/command when the subject has no other choice
Will	I will go to Delhi next week. Oil will float on water. He will always tell a lie. I will work very hard.	shows future planning shows a fact shows a present habit shows determination
Would	He said that he would return in a week. I would like to have some coffee. I would rather resign than stoop so low. Would that I were a bird! When she was a child, she would talk a lot.	shows past tense of will shows liking shows preference shows a wish/desire shows past habit
Shall	I shall go to Delhi next week. Shall I come tomorrow? Shall we go for a walk? You shall love your neighbour as yourself. He shall get a prize tomorrow.	shows a future planning shows asking for listener's will shows making suggestion shows command shows promise
Need	You need not buy a new dress.	shows absence of necessity
Dare	How dare you enter my office?	shows challenge/courage
Used to	Before his accident, he used to be a swimmer.	shows a discontinued habit or routine

Exercise: Fill in the blanks with appropriate modal auxiliaries. Also mention the expression which the modal used by you in each sentence shows, in the space provided.

1.that he were here!

2. I try to improve next time.

3. We go for a picnic next week.

4. Youreport on time at any cost.

5.I make some tea for you?

6. I assure you that he be rewarded for his bravery.

7. Younot leave this place.

8. My father left home at 5 o' clock. He.....reach here any time.

9. How.....you mess with me?

10. Heto smoke a lot when he was young.

11. My grandmothertell me stories.

12. She asked if she.....read my book.

13.his soul rest in peace!

14. Therebe a hotel in the heart of the city.

15. You wear a helmet.